MAËLAN TOMASEK

Researcher, Veterinarian & Author

www.maelantomasek.com

MY BACKGROUND

I am a researcher (PhD), vet (DVM) and science communicator interested in animal behaviour and cognition

INTERESTS

Animal cognition
Science communication
Statistical analyses
Veterinary medicine

SKILLS

- Experimental designer with aquatic animals (CNRS degree)
- Scientific diver
- R, Python, The Observer®
- English (C2, CAE), French (C2), Spanish (B2), German (B1), Czech (A2), Italian (A2)

PERSONAL HOBBIES

Athletics, piano, reading with a good earl grey tea and my cat

CONTACT INFORMATION

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3141 South Yarra, VIC, Australia

CURRENT POSITION

Post-doctoral researcher 2026 - Current

Supervision

Bob Wong

Behavioural Ecology Research Group
Monash University, Melbourne, Australia

Aquatic Newtons: intuitive physics in goldfish

This project aims at exploring how fish comprehend and use the rules of physics in their aquatic world. More specifically, I am interested in their appraisal of buoyancy, gravity, and drag.

SELECTED SCIENTIFIC WORKS

PUBLICATIONS

Tomasek M, Dunster B, Goverts Z, Naceur D, Dufour V*, & Jordan A* (2026) Decision rules diverge between sympatric Featherfin cichlids despite shared preferences, ecology, and evolutionary history. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences U.S.A.*
https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2620602123

Tomasek M, Soller K, Jordan A (2025) Wild fish use visual cues to recognise individual divers. *Biology Letters.*
http://doi.org/10.1098/rsbl.2024.0558

Tomasek M, Soller K, Dufour V*, Jordan A* (2024) Differences in inhibitory control in two species of Tanganyikan bower-building cichlids contrasting in building flexibility. *Ecology & Evolution.*
https://doi.org/10.1002/ece3.11406

Tomasek M, Stark M, Dufour V*, Jordan A* (2023) Cognitive flexibility in a Tanganyikan bower-building cichlid, *Aulonocranus dewindti*. *Animal Cognition.*
https://doi.org/10.1007/s10071-023-01830-w

Tomasek M, Ravignani A, Boucherie P H, Van Meye S, Dufour, V (2023) Spontaneous vocal coordination of vocalizations to water noise in rooks (*Corvus frugilegus*): an exploratory study. *Ecology and Evolution*
https://doi.org/10.1002/ece3.9791

THESES

Tomasek M (2025) The evolution of cognitive abilities in an adaptive radiation model: Tanganyikan cichlids. PhD thesis.
https://theses.hal.science/tel-05612958v1
Awarded Best PhD thesis of 2025 by the French Society for the Study of Animal Behaviour (SFECA)

Tomasek M (2022) Impact of health in behavioural and cognitive research: focus on aquatic organisms (in French). Veterinary thesis.
https://dumas.ccsd.cnrs.fr/dumas-03934194

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SELECTED ORAL PRESENTATIONS

Decision-making strategies of two related fish species diverge under increased perceptual load (2025)
Awarded Best student talk, **SFECA Congress, Nanterre, France**

Inhibitory control in Tanganyikan bower-building cichlids covaries with bower complexity (2025)
ISBE Congress, Melbourne, Australia

Growing wild: Fish cognition in the field (2025)
Invited speaker, Hólar University, Iceland

Pubescent teenagers or Tanganyikan cichlids? Cognitive experiments with unmotivated wild fish (2023)
Awarded Best Student Talk, **Behaviour Congress, Bielefeld, Germany**

SELECTED SCIENCE COMMUNICATION WORKS

Science fiction novel: *The Ceiling* (Original title: *Le Plafond*) (2025, ed. Librinova)
Shortlisted for the Librinova Star Prize 2025

Three Minutes Thesis competition: 2nd National Jury Prize; 1st Local Jury Prize & Audience Prize

Podcasts: *Savant Sachant Chercher* (2024); *Principes Fondamentaux* (2025)

COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENTS

Association Ethosph'R (Board member since 2025)
Scientific association for animal welfare, laboratory animal rehabilitation and resocialisation, and science communication on ethology

SFECA Early Career Researchers' Group
Organization of a congress to discuss ethical challenges in ethology (diversity and inclusion, animal welfare, environmental impacts)

WORK EXPERIENCE

CICHLID COGNITION (Social learning, field experiments)
January-May 2022 - Alex Jordan, Max Planck Institute of Animal Behaviour Konstanz, Germany

ROOK COGNITION (Theory of mind, dominance relationships)
Summer 2020 - Valérie Dufour, Cognitive and Social Ethology, CNRS Strasbourg, France

CEPHALOPOD HATCHLING BEHAVIOUR (Stress regulation, imprinting)
Summer 2018 - Anne-SophieDarmaillacq,Laboratoire Ethos, CNRS Caen, France

ROOK VOCALISATIONS (Biomusicology)
Summer 2017 - Valérie Dufour, Cognitive and Social Ethology, CNRS Strasbourg, France

EDUCATION, TRAINING, & DEGREES

UNIV. CLERMONT-AUVERGNE & MAX PLANCK INSTITUTE OF ANIMAL BEHAVIOUR
2022 - 2025
PhD, The evolution of cognitive abilities in the Tanganyikan cichlid adaptive radiation
Supervision: Valérie Dufour (LAPSCO, CNRS & UCA, France) & Alex Jordan (MPIAB, Germany)

VETERINARY SCHOOL OF LYON
2017 - 2022
Doctorate of Veterinary Medicine, Self-specialization in fish medicine

ÉCOLE NORMALE SUPERIEURE DE LYON
2016 - 2022
Bachelor'sand Master's degrees in Biosciences

CLAUDE BERNARD UNIVERSITY - LYON
2017 - 2019
Master's degree in Biomedical Research: Behavioural Psychobiology, Biostatistics and Modelisation